

The Eagle

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Eagle was a high-quality magazine for boys in the 1950s. It came into being through the collaboration of an impoverished Vicar from Southport in Lancashire and a student at Southport College of Art. The Vicar of St James's Church, Birkdale, the Rev. Marcus Morris, had transformed his parish magazine from a 4-page leaflet into a shiny Christian publication employing a young Frank Hampson to provide illustrations, cartoons and eye-catching front covers.

A children's section in *The Anvil* set Marcus thinking about the possibility of producing a Christian adventure story magazine for boys to counteract the grisly American comics widely available in the 1940s. Between them, Marcus and Frank first produced strip cartoon hero Lex Christian, a tough fighting parson in the East End of London who, after a series of vicissitudes, morphed into Dan Dare, Pilot of the Future.

Frank proved to be a genius with the strip cartoon format and was soon working on a dummy for a magazine. Marcus was paying Frank out of his stipend, so it became vital to find a publisher. On the brink of bankruptcy, Marcus took the train to London and Fleet Street. Publisher after publisher turned him down until he knocked on the door of Hulton Press, publisher of *Picture Post*, *Farmers Weekly*, *Lilliput* and *Housewife*. The company needed a major boost, and the management team of John Pearce and Ronnie Dickenson had the courage to gamble on an unknown provincial parson.

By November 1949 Marcus, Frank and the team of artists and writers they had assembled were on Hulton's payroll and Marcus's most pressing debts had been paid off. However, the creators of *Eagle* received no royalties or copyright – Marcus was too naïve, and too relieved to have avoided bankruptcy and defrocking, to argue the point.



1950's Magazine Mastheads

The first issue of *Eagle* appeared on Friday, 14 April 1950. A team of artists and writers had been assembled, a studio in Southport found, and Marcus spent his weeks in Fleet Street, returning north at weekends to write sermons and conduct services. Bemrose in Liverpool designed and built a rotary press capable of printing eight pages in full colour and up to a million copies a week.

The publicity campaign was huge. Humber Hawk cars with large papier-mâché eagles on their roofs toured the country distributing tokens. National advertising targeted parents, and copies of the first issue were sent to schools, clergy, youth clubs and the Scout movement.

A million copies had been ordered, 900,000 were printed, and very few were left over. This was the beginning of a decade in which a whole generation of boys (and girls) enjoyed good, clean fun with educational overtones. Readers were enthralled by Dan Dare, PC49, Riders of the Range, Tommy Walls and Luck of the Legion. Captain Pugwash began his career in *Eagle*, while Harris Tweed, Chicko, cutaway drawings and the Special Investigator were also favourites. The religious and moral framework was strong but not overstated, and the MUGS scheme and *Eagle Club* encouraged good citizenship.

Sales of *Eagle* continued in the hundreds of thousands. In due course, *Eagle* was joined by *Girl* (though many girls preferred *Eagle*), *Swift* for younger readers and *Robin* for the very youngest. All were successful, though none matched *Eagle's* popularity.

It all started to go wrong in March 1959, when Hulton Press was taken over by Odhams Press. Relationships between the Hulton/*Eagle* stalwarts and the new management did not prosper. Marcus left the company in September to join the National Magazine Company. Frank stayed unhappily until the summer of 1961, by which time Odhams had been taken over by the Mirror Group. From then on, *Eagle* degenerated into a comic. In 1963 it was merged with *Swift*; *Girl* and *Robin* then disappeared and in April.